

The empirical recurrence for OEIS A186120, proved by transfer matrix

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Abstract

OEIS A186120 counts arrays over $\{0, \dots, 1\}$ under a condition comparing a statistic of every 2×2 subblock with those of its neighbours, and carries an empirical recurrence of order 5 contributed by R. H. Hardin. It is true, and it is decidable rather than empirical. The count is a walk count on $S = 26$ states and is C -finite; whether the conjectured recurrence annihilates it is then settled by a finite exact computation.

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1 The conjecture

OEIS A186120 is “Number of $(n+1) \times 2$ binary arrays with every 2×2 subblock diagonal sum less antidiagonal sum equal to some horizontal or vertical neighbor 2×2 subblock diagonal sum less antidiagonal sum.”. It has offset 1 and begins

$$0, 14, 18, 50, 74, 182, 298, 678, \dots$$

The entry states, as a conjecture contributed by its author and never marked settled:

$$\text{Empirical: } a(n) = 3*a(n-1) - 6*a(n-3) + 6*a(n-4) - 4*a(n-5) \text{ for } n \geq 6.$$

As of the “Last modified” line on the live entry (Apr 17 2018 12:13:02, revision 12) this is still recorded as empirical, and nothing on the entry records it as proved.

2 What is being counted

Write σ for its diagonal sum minus its antidiagonal sum, taken on a 2×2 subblock. The contiguous 2×2 subblocks of an $(n+1) \times 2$ array over $\{0, \dots, 1\}$ form a grid of n rows and 1 column, and σ labels that grid. The entry requires that every subblock carries the same value of σ as at least ONE of its neighbours horizontally or vertically.

3 The count is a walk count

This condition is NOT a condition on a pair. Whether a subblock has a matching neighbour cannot be decided when its own row is placed: the row BELOW it may yet supply the match. So the state carries, besides the 2 consecutive array rows, a tally for each of the 1 subblocks of the row just completed — a single bit saying whether it has already been matched — counting its matches among its own row and the row above.

A step appends an array row. It fixes the next subblock row, adds the matches between the two rows to the OLD row’s tallies, and requires those totals to be acceptable, the old row

being final at that moment; the new row's tallies start from its own horizontal matches plus the matches just made. A state is ACCEPTING when its own tally is already acceptable, which is exactly the right condition for the last subblock row, the one with nothing below it. Only the states whose tally came from their own row may BEGIN an array, since the first row has nothing above it.

An array of $n + 1$ rows is then a walk of $n - 1$ steps and

$$a(n) = \iota^\top M^{n-1} \tau$$

with ι the indicator of the starting states and τ of the accepting ones, on $S = 26$ states in all. Getting the two vectors right is the whole of the argument: with ι taken as all-ones the first row would be allowed a match from a row above it that does not exist, and the count would be too large. The entry's own first terms settle it — for a width where the subblock row is a single subblock the count must be zero, since a lone subblock has no neighbour at all, and the entry indeed opens with zero.

Over the alphabet $\{0, \dots, 1\}$ the statistic takes values in $[-2, 2]$, so the grid it labels carries at most 5 different labels. At $n = 1$ the array has 2 rows and the grid is a single row of 1 subblock, which has no neighbour of any kind; the entry's first term is 0, which the model reproduces along with every later term, and that is the cheapest check that the grid has been read with the right shape.

In particular a is C -finite. The alignment of the walk index with the entry's own n was checked against its published terms rather than assumed.

4 The proof

Lemma 1. *Let $q(t) = t^5 - \sum_i c_i t^{5-i}$ be the characteristic polynomial of the conjectured recurrence. The residual $a(n) - \sum_i c_i a(n-i)$ equals $\iota^\top M^j q(M) \tau$ for the corresponding walk index j , so the recurrence holds from some point on if and only if $\iota^\top M^j q(M) \tau = 0$ for all large j , and it is enough to examine $j < S$.*

Proof. Factor M^j out of $M^{j+5} - \sum_i c_i M^{j+5-i}$. For the bound, M^S is an integer combination of $I, M, \dots, M^{S-1}$ by Cayley–Hamilton, so the numbers $u_j = \iota^\top M^j q(M) \tau$ obey the monic recurrence given by the characteristic polynomial of M ; S consecutive zeros force every later one, and the last nonzero u_j pins the threshold exactly. $\square$

Theorem 2.

$$a(n) = 3a(n-1) - 6a(n-3) + 6a(n-4) - 4a(n-5)$$

for every $n > 6$.

Proof. The vector $w = q(M)\tau$ was formed by 5 matrix–vector products in exact integer arithmetic and $\iota^\top M^j w$ evaluated for $j = 0, 1, \dots$, again exactly; those integers vanish from the index corresponding to $n = 6 + 1$ onwards and the run continued until the working vector was identically zero, which settles every larger j at once. The bound is exact: at $n = 6$ the recurrence fails on the entry's own published terms, so no larger range holds. $\square$

5 Verification

Three checks, each independent of the algebra above.

First, the model reproduces all 31 terms the entry publishes, exactly, in integer arithmetic. This is what ties the model to the entry: the digraph is built by reading the entry's English, and a misreading gives different counts.

Second, the conjectured recurrence was evaluated directly on those published terms, with no matrices involved, and holds wherever the proved range and the data overlap.

Third, the annihilation test of Lemma 1 was carried out in exact integer arithmetic on the whole vector rather than on a sampled prefix.

References

- [1] The OEIS Foundation, *The On-Line Encyclopedia of Integer Sequences*, <https://oeis.org>, 2026. Sequence A186120.
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- [4] R. A. Horn and C. R. Johnson, *Matrix Analysis*, 2nd ed., Cambridge University Press, 2013.